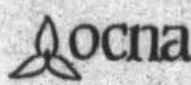


The Almonte Gazette

A RUNGE PUBLISHING INC. PUBLICATION
FOUNDED 1867
P.O. Box 130, Almonte, Ontario, KOA 1A0
BUSINESS OFFICE - 86 Mill Street, Almonte.
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Publisher - Jeffrey Maguire
Editor - Theresa Fritz



Director of Group Sales - Bryan Wiltsie
Advertising Sales - Marjory McBride

ANNUAL SUBSCRIPTIONS
CANADA - \$36.00/yr., SENIORS - \$34.00/yr.
U.S. - \$75.00/yr., INTERNATIONAL - \$135.00/yr.
(All rates, except outside Canada, GST included)

Member of the Ontario Community Newspapers Assoc.
and the Canadian Community Newspapers Assoc.
Also a member of the Audit Bureau of Circulations
(Published every Wednesday)

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Jean Chretien fails test of leadership

Winning a majority government in Canada means never having to admit your mistakes. This is apparently the 'lesson' Prime Minister Jean Chretien garnered from the bitter, personal and shallow election of last November 27.

The Prime Minister revealed his lack of humility during recent year-end interviews conducted by Canada's major television news networks. Especially galling was his steadfast claim that he did not once engage in personal attacks on his opponents during the recent election campaign. At the same time, Chretien bemoaned the mean-spirited nature of his opponents.

The majority of Canadians, regardless of their political affiliation, have pointed to the 2000 federal election as an example of politics at its worst. The election campaign focused on personalities to the exclusion of almost every important issue facing Canada. Even health care, the primary issue for a majority of Canadians, became a flash point for empty and partisan rhetoric.

We believe all political parties deserve some blame for shaping such a listless and shallow debate. However the Prime Minister's attitude warrants an especially harsh censure. When the nation's top politician fails to acknowledge errors in judgement, the damage to the political process is enduring. Chretien has failed a key test of leadership by refusing to share in the blame for a campaign that further alienated millions of Canadians from the political process.

Chretien did face harsh charges during the course of the campaign. He was accused of criminal acts, arrogance and an unhealthy desire for power by his opponents. However, he and his allies responded with vitriolic attacks that crossed the line on too many occasions. In fact, Chretien opened the campaign by openly suggesting that the new Canadian Alliance party was not simply promoting an agenda that he disagreed with, but was fundamentally "un-Canadian" at the core.

With a few unfortunate exceptions, the supposed 'personal' attacks launched by party leaders Stockwell Day, Gilles Duceppe, Alexa McDonough and Joe Clark, upon Jean Chretien, were focused on documented events. His opponents criticized an undeniably early election call, documented spending irregularities and incidents in Chretien's riding that have produced active and ongoing police investigations. While the tone of their attacks was often unnecessarily shrill, the questions they raised were substantive and necessary.

Chretien has the right to be offended by any baseless accusations levelled by his opponents. But as the Prime Minister he also has a responsibility to show leadership and restraint. Unfortunately his operatives chose to lash out at their political opponents and in particular at the Canadian Alliance.

Minister of Immigration Elinor Caplan labelled her Canadian Alliance opponents as racists and Holocaust deniers. Liberal spin-doctor Warren Kinsella utilized a stuffed dinosaur to mock Stockwell Day's creationist beliefs. In both instances these Liberal operatives chose contemptuous stereotyping, over informed debate.

But when confronted with these incidents by his media interviewers, the Prime Minister noted that he himself had not authored those personal attacks. However, he refused to disown the antics of his underlings.

Regrettably, after almost 40 years in public life, Chretien was unable to seize the moment and set aside partisan concerns. After securing a comfortable majority in Parliament, that ensures his 'legacy' of three consecutive Liberal majorities, he had nothing to lose by admitting to his role in a flawed election. Unfortunately he turned down the opportunity to show real leadership by admitting that politicians of all parties could learn from the mistakes of the recent federal election. His attitude suggests that in four years Canadians may well be subjected to an even greater exercise in cynicism.

Prime Minister Jean Chretien is not solely responsible for bringing this destructive brand of attack politics to Canada. However, he is the sole politician with the national stature to effectively speak out against its continuation. And by choosing to ignore his role in alienating voters from the political process, he has damaged the electoral process in Canada.

OPINION



Slippery when wet.

Photo by Phil Ambroziak

Plow the road clear in the new year

On a clear day

By Brent Dowdall



I loved 2000, but I'm glad to see it gone. Not because it wasn't a good year, but almost because it was too good a year in our lives. It was like having too many Turtles chocolates - eventually you want to try the Pot of Gold box.

For my wife and I, it was non-stop. Between our first new house, our wedding, our honeymoon, a collapsed ceiling, my first full year on the job at *The Gazette*, some volunteer activity, two elections two weeks apart and other priorities too numerous to mention, I can't imagine a busier year.

Sure, there's going to be plenty of craziness in the odyssey that will be 2001 - two more weddings for sure in the family, the challenges of work, winter and other happenings - but I'm looking forward to being a little more organized. If I have a New Year's resolution, along with more exercise, being more organized will be it. I'm sure the staff of *The Gazette* will appreciate it, especially on Tuesday mornings.

Before we move onto 2001, though, something that has to be cleared off, a pet peeve of mine for a couple of years now. That is a stretch of road on County Road 29/Regional Road 29, specifically between Arnprior and Pakenham.

If the new City of Ottawa is looking for a New Year's resolution for this end of its new territory, I have one for them - that they will do a better job of plowing Regional Road 29 from

Arnprior to Pakenham.

For many people traveling in either direction, it's a critical link, for those driving from the Upper Ottawa Valley in Lanark County or beyond, and for those heading north from these parts. And quite bluntly, the road is not properly cared for during bad winter weather. In fact, it's terrible, and it's dangerous.

What's stunning is there is such a dramatic difference as one travels the road. From Almonte to Pakenham, the road is generally about as well maintained as can be expected in bad winter. But from the Walter Bradley Road just north of Pakenham to the Highway 17 intersection at Arnprior, it's a disaster - there's no other way to describe it.

Lanark County looks after the road south of Pakenham, while the northern stretch is the responsibility of the regional government - now the City of Ottawa. What will happen in the new city is anyone's guess, but the road has not been safe for years now following a snowstorm. It looks like it has never been touched with a plow. It's especially bad considering the difference between the section

Lanark County does compared to that done by the region.

I did speak with Bill Beveridge, the region's director of maintenance, about how that road is maintained. What I got was a technical briefing about how they look after the road. Through use of technology with a micro-weather station, they measure the pavement temperature and use liquid de-icer as well as granular salt to thaw the pavement. That, says Beveridge, prevents the ice from packing on the road and bonding with the pavement, as well as uses less salt.

The problem is the snow is not taken off the road, even if the right chemicals are applied to the surface. After a snowfall, it's like driving in a farmer's field, with only the tracks of the vehicle in front of you as a guide. Quite honestly, it looks like no one has touched the road with a plow.

It would be one thing if this was a local road, but it's not. Until three years ago, it was a provincial highway, and in many ways, it still is. The tractor trailers are still on the road, and so is commuter traffic between Renfrew and Lanark counties, along

with farm vehicles too. Yet when one drives it after a snowfall, one goes from a reasonably well-plowed road south of Pakenham to a dangerous stretch from Arnprior to Pakenham.

The road has to be treated as a major road, and the regional government doesn't seem to do so. Yes, it pays attention to it, but the highway is considered a Tier II road in terms of traffic. I'm no expert in traffic management or safety, but I know what I see, and I hear what others see, and the consensus is the regional stretch of the road is not up to scratch.

Now that I've gotten that off my chest, bring on 2001, now that there can be no argument that we are now in the third millennium. It should be an interesting year to see what the economy does and whether the 'new economy' is for real, as well as whether new governments in the US and an old government here can do what they said they would do last fall.

Around these parts, too, it should be an interesting time, as Mississippi Mills is no longer a baby but a toddler. I can't say I have a crystal ball, but I expect we'll hear a lot more about capitalizing on growth while retaining small-town charm, and plenty about the flourishing arts community. Heck, we might even hear about a local road plowed as it should be.

Let's get it started.

LETTERS

Decisions about business park sign explained

To the Editor:

Gail Taggart makes some very thoughtful comments in your December 13 issue about the business park sign. I am a member of the Business Park Sub-Committee of the Community and Economic Development Committee and since I volunteered to co-ordinate the production of this sign, I feel it is I who must respond.

On her first point, I should explain that the construction trades were very busy this year, and we were able to get the best conditions for this work by agreeing to allow them to work on this project in between other work they were already committed to. Demanding quicker completion would have forced us to pay a premium. She should be assured that the length of time taken reach completion does not determine the ultimate cost.

Her second point makes reference to the location of the sign. I want her to know that I too would have like the sign to be closer to the corner so that it could be more visible from Ottawa Street. We did place it just as far out as we could, but we were constrained by the radius required for vehicles turning onto Industrial Drive.

Finally, as to trees, an effort was made to move trees back from the corner and not to place evergreen trees too close to the corner. I believe that it will be a while before trees

restrict the visibility of the sign. If, after the passage of time, they appear to block the view, this issue will certainly be addressed again.

I am relieved that she did not criticize the appearance of the sign, since I must take some credit or blame for the way it looks. By the way, the sign is still not finished, and she will notice more changes next spring when final touches are added to the stone pillars and the landscaping (at no extra cost to the town, I might add).

Yours very truly,
Peter Moller

New street lights shine brightly to perfection

To the Editor:

I read Madeleine Moir's letter in the December 20 *Gazette* on the subject of Almonte's new Mill Street lights with interest. She commented particularly on the memories that they evoked of her childhood in Manchester in the 1920s and 1930s. Indeed, the new lights do have an antique character that is quite in keeping with the program to enhance the appearance of our downtown street. They fit well, and I am quite pleased with the overall appearance.

More than that, from an engineering and astronomical point of view, they also conform to modern standards for public lighting. Although a daytime view would suggest that the light is emitted from the antique glass lamp chimney behind the glass windows, it is actually emitted from

a lamp housed in the metal roof of the fixture. The result is that most of the light is directed downward where it provides maximum illumination to the street and sidewalk, and a minimum is directed horizontally where it would contribute to annoying glare.

As an amateur astronomer I also appreciate the fact that the design also emits no light upwards where it would only contribute to sky glow and so make the night sky more difficult to observe and enjoy.

On the whole, my kudos to all involved in the selection and installation of the new lights. They are a very positive improvement to our downtown by all measures.

Al Seaman
Almonte

Teachers do a lot for students

To the Editor:

This letter is in regards to the labor dispute between the Catholic District School Board of Eastern Ontario and its teachers.

In collective bargaining between school boards and teachers fairness and equity in the outcome relies on the good faith of both parties. That good faith was broken on September 1, when the board unilaterally changed the teachers' working conditions. Only four Catholic boards across the province chose this line of action.

Predictably, in all four areas the teachers reacted in the same way. Teachers had three options available to them. One was to do nothing and

accept the cuts. The second was to walk out on a full strike. The third was to begin the school year, continue teaching, and to impose sanctions to put pressure on the Board to resolve the negotiations in a fair, negotiated way. The first and second options were not the appropriate reactions at that time. Teachers chose third. They chose to stand up for themselves because teachers should have reasonable working conditions so that the can do their jobs well.

Undoubtedly, sanctions have a negative effect on the atmosphere of school life. Teachers give generously of their own free time to enrich students' experiences of school. They fill our book orders, collect money, balance it, and write personal cheques so that students can buy inexpensive books and are encouraged to read. They collect money, tack it, lose part of their own lunch time to distribute food, so that students can have hot lunches and so that school councils can raise money.

They coach teams after school. They organize concerts, dances, musicals, sporting events, masses, play music for celebrations, run practices, rehearse choirs, rehearse readers, make costumes, decorations. They decorate hallway bulletin boards, classroom bulletin boards, often with materials bought with their own money.

-- See Letters page 5